LOCAL

Zach Caudle | What happens to you when you challenge the system

Zach Caudle

Augusta Free Press

Published date: October 28, 2026 | 12:02 pm

Add as a preferred source on Google

Share

Loading Audio Player By Instaread, Please Wait...



Photo: © gpisano71/Adobe Stock

In July of this year, I put up signs to educate my neighbors in the **Town of Elkton** about **Flock license plate reader cameras** and how they could help me get rid of them in our small town. At the time, I was

to report what I saw as destruction of property. The deputy who responded was **Deputy B.R. Fix**. I'll admit my first interaction with Deputy Fix wasn't bad. He was cordial and seemed eager to help me navigate the report. That didn't last.

Shortly after the Town of Elkton voted 5-0 to cancel its Flock contract, I learned that the Sheriff's Office was gearing up to use the system, even as its local partners were getting rid of the technology. I sent a FOIA request to the Sheriff's Office, as I had to several other law enforcement agencies in the county. The Sheriff's Office's own written response confirmed that no meetings were held with any county board before the cameras went up. There was no Board of Supervisors vote and no public hearing.

On **July 27th**, I went to the Sheriff's Office in **Harrisonburg** to pick up FOIA documents. On my way home, I passed the Flock camera at **McGaheysville Elementary**, and as I reached the Elkton town limits, Deputy Fix pulled me over. I was confused. I was paying attention, everything seemed fine, and I didn't believe I had been going anywhere near the speed he claimed. This encounter was not as cordial as our first. He seemed irritated and said little beyond "**73 in a 55**, let me see your license." I handed it over.

I used to believe in coincidence. I no longer do. The timing of that stop raised questions for me. Either I had crossed paths with a deputy acting on his own, or with a Sheriff's Office intent on making clear that questioning its decisions would not be tolerated.

So, I filed another FOIA request, this time for the records of that stop, including body and dash camera footage and the calibration records for Deputy Fix's radar unit.

After reviewing the documentation, and learning that hadn't been recalibrated in the six months prior to the stop, I decided to fight the ticket. I believed I was being retaliated against, but in court I stuck to what I could prove.

When I arrived for court on **October 15th**, the judge noted that the **Commonwealth's Attorney** was not prosecuting several cases, and told a group of us, about 10 to 15 people, that our tickets had been dismissed. I left the courthouse satisfied. I felt that this time the system had worked, and that I had used the law to push back against what I believed was intimidation. I was wrong.

Eight days later, on **October 23rd**, I was riding my motorcycle on **Route 33**, headed home to Elkton from Harrisonburg, when a marked Sheriff's Office cruiser turned around and began following me. I didn't know who was behind the wheel, but I had a very uneasy feeling. The

cruiser then turned on its emergency lights and pulled me over.

I pulled into the **7-Eleven** in **Penn Laird**, and lo and behold, Deputy Fix stepped out of the cruiser. He first told me he had stopped me because he couldn't see my license plate. When I challenged that, he said I had cut off a truck when I turned onto Lawyer Road. I hadn't. I signaled and had plenty of room. When I challenged that, too, he shifted a third time, to the lane markings. He also told me he had first followed me for speed, but admitted he never got a speed reading.

I asked for a supervisor. Instead of using his radio, Deputy Fix got into his cruiser and called someone on a cell phone, then told me a supervisor was on the way. After some time, with no supervisor in sight, he came back with a summons for failure to obey lane markings. He told me a supervisor wasn't coming after all, that I could call their office, and then he left.

About 30 minutes later, I filed a formal complaint with the Sheriff's Office. I have also requested the footage and records from that stop.

This is what happens when you don't just lie down and take tyranny. This is what happens when you ask questions. I don't know whether this is one deputy acting on his own or an approach that comes from the top of the Sheriff's Office. But I do know that I'm stubborn. I won't lie down and let you kick me, and I will use every civil means I have to bring to light the dark that covers this department.

Keep asking questions. Keep searching for the truth. And if this ever happens to you, remember: it's because you're asking the right questions.

FEATURED VIDEO

Zach Caudle

Augusta Free Press

View all posts by Zach Caudle

LOCAL

Zach Caudle | What happens to you when you challenge the system

ZACH CAUDLE OCTOBER 28, 2026

Valerie Hayes case: Judge sorting through legal issues in Mennonite kidnapping



DORI ZOOK OCTOBER 28, 2026

Augusta County: Former Nexus Services CEO arrested on child sodomy charge



CHRIS GRAHAM OCTOBER 28, 2026

Waynesboro: Police searching for woman last in contact with family on Oct. 20



CHRIS GRAHAM OCTOBER 27, 2026

Albemarle County: Deer collision causes chain-reaction crash, death



CHRIS GRAHAM OCTOBER 27, 2026

Augusta County woman dies from injuries in overnight Interstate 64 accident



CHRIS GRAHAM OCTOBER 27, 2026

How we got here: Summary of U.S. v. Valerie Hayes, the 'Mennonite kidnapping' case



DORI ZOOK OCTOBER 26, 2026

Staunton: Fire department relocating temporarily due to renovations



CHRIS GRAHAM OCTOBER 26, 2026

ICYMI

3 Waynesboro: Family pressing for answers after child dropped off at wrong bus stop

4 How you can help an Augusta County family get through a tough battle with cancer

5 UVA Basketball: Catching up with Kyle Guy, back playing overseas after coaching gig

LATEST NEWS

LOCAL

Waynesboro: Family seeks information on man reported missing on Aug. 30

CHRIS GRAHAM OCTOBER 28, 2026

FOOTBALL, GO 'HOOS

Jahmal Edrine case: The repercussions hanging in the balance for UVA Athletics

CHRIS GRAHAM OCTOBER 28, 2026

LOCAL

Augusta County: Former Nexus Services CEO arrested on child sodomy charge

CHRIS GRAHAM OCTOBER 28, 2026

FOOTBALL

ACC Football: Players of the Week for Week 8, courtesy the select media panel

CHRIS GRAHAM OCTOBER 27, 2026

FOOTBALL

ACC Football: #1 Miami among three ranked teams in action on Saturday

CHRIS GRAHAM OCTOBER 27, 2026

GO 'HOOS, SPORTS

Golf: Miranda Lu leads UVA women to win in inaugural Keswick Cup

CHRIS GRAHAM OCTOBER 27, 2026

Copyright © 2026 Augusta Free Press LLC. All Rights Reserved.